

What is Electronic Music?

I. Introduction and Early History

In the most basic sense, electronic music fires electrical impulses with devices such as drum machines and synthesizers to create an infinite range of tones and rhythms. These machines generate and manipulate waveforms, such as sine waves, to create different musical effects. Electronic musicians often layer multiple waveforms on top of each other to add depth to the instrumental. While musicians have been experimenting with sound generation via the help of electronics since the early 20th century, I don't consider this to be the birth of electronic music. During this time, electronic music was primarily restricted to the avant-garde and academic circle, primarily focusing on the development of the "Musique Concrete" genre, which "utilizes recorded sounds as raw material". Karlheinz Stockhausen is considered the father of electronic music due to his focus on electronic sound modifications rather than tape manipulation. Stockhausen's compositions used both electronically modified acoustic sounds alongside electronically produced sounds, leading to the birth of "Elektronische Musik", emphasizing the purity of electronic sound. With the arrival of consumer-level Japanese electronic percussion instruments in the 1950s came the mainstream accessibility of electronic music and thus the merging of electronic music with other genres such as rock and pop. During the 1980s, "electronic dance music" emerged as a prominent genre encompassing subgenres from different scenes around the world. In the UK, for example, Jamaican reggae artists began experimenting with synthesizers and audio sampling, leading to the creation of dub, jungle, as well as drum and bass. In Detroit, black musicians such as Derrick May and Kevin Saunderson fused German synth pop (particularly inspired by German collective Kraftwerk) with genres such as funk and house to create techno. While there is a seemingly infinite number of electronic subgenres today, they can all be categorized into one of two umbrella groups: electronica and electronic dance music (EDM).

II. Electronica

As the name implies, electronic dance music is created for the purpose of dancing, while electronica is created for the purpose of listening. Obviously, all music is created for the purpose of being listened to, but electronica is specifically composed to create beautiful and unique soundscapes. Electronica doesn't have one single, distinct sound but rather includes a wide array of genres, ranging from drill and bass (160-180+ BPM) to ambient (90-100 BPM). The importance of electronica doesn't come from its experimental sounds, but rather the significant influence it has played on the music scene to this day. Electronica artists such as Aphex Twin and Autechre are accredited with popularizing 'digital audio workstations' (DAWs), a tool used in almost every popular song today. Electronica's emphasis on experimental sound manipulation has led to an explosion of innovative sound design in music today. Artists across genres experiment with complex textures and atmospheric soundscapes, a pillar of electronica music production. Early electronica exploration of algorithms and generative music has even paved the way for the integration of artificial intelligence in music production. Culturally, electronica proved to a generation of independent musicians that good sounding music didn't have to be made in a traditional studio setting. The legacy of electronica music lies not only in its innovative soundscapes but also its profound influence on modern music production.

III. Electronic Dance Music

Electronic Dance Music is one of the most popular music genres today, serving as a platform for people of all ages to express themselves freely. EDM is well-known for its PLUR culture (“Peace Love Unity Respect”), a set of ethics to promote inclusion and respect among fans. While PLUR is a new development in the rave scene, it stands for a much larger movement synonymous with EDM: counterculture. EDM is rooted in the underground, with promoters hosting illegal free raves in commercial warehouses around the world during the 90s. These spaces served as safe havens for marginalized communities to express themselves freely. The EDM scene’s wide range of subgenres reflects its diverse and inclusive nature, embracing the euphoric melodies of trance to the gritty rhythm of dubstep. This attitude popularized the genre among generations of young people, especially now as Gen Z suffers from an excess of anxiety and awkwardness, EDM provides them with a space to express themselves without fear of embarrassment. While some consider EDM as purely a music genre, it is more appropriate to frame it as a movement of free expression with a distinct cultural and social impact.

IV. Conclusion

Electronic music isn’t just a genre, but rather a movement, an attitude that retorts the traditional definition of music. Some may argue that electronic music allows for an easy shortcut to musical creativity, but this perspective neglects the skill and creativity required in electronic music production. Electronic music challenges our traditional perception of music by creating a musical platform only limited by the user’s skill rather than their paycheck. While traditional music production requires the purchase of expensive equipment, electronic music only requires a working computer for one to express themselves freely. Herein lies the beauty of electronic music: accessibility. By lowering the barrier to entry, electronic music opens the door to a diverse range of voices and ideas, democratizing the creative process.